

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

RISKY GAMBIT
Congress leader Sachin Pilot sitting on fast in Jaipur, April 11



ASHOK GEHLOT
Rajasthan Chief Minister

VASUNDHARA RAJE
Former Rajasthan chief minister



store during Raje's first tenure (2003-08) and former IPL chief Lalit Modi's alleged influence over the Raje regime. The Congress had milked these issues to come to power earlier. But, the Supreme Court has dismissed the carpets case long ago, and even the case concerning Modi buying shares in Raje and her son Dushyant's Dholpur Palace property for a whopping price was dismissed in courts.

So, was Pilot's fast just another attempt to push for a greater say in Congress affairs in Rajasthan, especially the ticket allocation, or he genuinely feels bringing up the graft issues can dent the BJP's prospects in the upcoming state election? "Why was he silent for four years when he could have raised the issue of alleged corruption during the BJP regime in the assembly or outside?" questions Rajendra Rathore, leader of the opposition. Pilot says he wrote to Gehlot on the issue twice in the past year and was forced to sit on a fast when he got no response. However, Randhawa, who was appointed the state in-charge in December, is annoyed that Pilot not for once brought up these issues before him in the last four months. After a meeting with AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge on April 12, he hinted at imminent "action" against Pilot. But will the Gandhis allow it?

Many feel that Pilot is now at risk of getting even more isolated within the Congress even if the high command chooses not to act against him. In Rajasthan, his party colleagues say he is ruining whatever chances the Congress has to retain power. Perhaps Pilot realised late that targeting Gehlot and Raje solely would not be enough. So by the time the fast was over, he expanded his "movement" to target alleged corruption in the BJP-ruled Centre and Karnataka. Both Gehlot and Raje, meanwhile, chose to remain silent and let their partymen do the talking.

For Gehlot, it was business as usual, as he on April 12 addressed a press conference on the newly announced 'Mehngai Rahat Camps' (relief camps against inflation), where people can register themselves to get subsidies and enhanced monetary assistance under 10 government schemes. Ignoring all queries about Pilot, Gehlot said the new programme was one more step towards his mission to make Rajasthan the best state on all parameters by 2030. Does it mean he is hoping to be CM at least till then? "That depends on the electorate, but I will continue to work towards achieving it in whatever position I am," he told INDIA TODAY.

That said, there is a section among political observers that sees a clear strategy behind Pilot's move, otherwise being dismissed as his flight of fantasy. There is a lobby within the BJP that wants to clip Raje's wings and neutralise Gehlot to end their alternate reigns in Rajasthan since 1998.

What about Pilot himself? Is he pushing his party to act against him so that he can join the BJP? Or could he be the Aam Aadmi Party's vehicle to enter Rajasthan on its anti-corruption plank? Will he float his own party ahead of the polls? As though events of the past three years weren't enough, the next few months will be full of political drama in the Rajasthan Congress camp. ■